

Understanding Informed Consent Forms

For Participating in Clinical Trials

Quick Tips – Care Guide



What Is Informed Consent?

Informed consent is communication between a medical care provider and a patient that results in the patient's understanding and authorization for a specific medical intervention.

- [OncLink - Informed Consent guidance](#)
- [American Cancer Society on Informed Consent for standard of care treatment](#)

What Is an Informed Consent Form?

An informed consent form helps you make informed decisions about participating in a cancer research study. It explains the study, your rights, potential risks and benefits, and what will be expected of you.

The form is part of the **informed consent process**, which is designed to protect your rights and ensure that participation is completely voluntary.

Before joining a study, you will have time to:

- Review the consent form
- Ask questions
- Discuss concerns with the research team
- Decide whether or not to participate

Federal law requires researchers to provide this information before enrollment.

What Information Is Included?

1. Study Overview

Explains:

- The purpose of the study
- The research question being investigated
- Potential risks and benefits
- Your responsibilities as a participant
- Alternatives to participation
- Reasons a participant may leave the study

Remember: Participation is voluntary, and you may leave the study at any time.

2. Study Design

Describes:

- Study groups and treatments
- Tests, procedures, and medications
- Number of participants
- Length of the study

3. Risks and Benefits

Provides information about:

- Known risks and possible side effects

- Potential benefits to participants
- How the study may help improve future treatment and understanding of disease

4. Costs

Explains:

- Which costs are covered by insurance or the study sponsor
- Any expenses you may be responsible for, such as travel or lodging

5. Your Rights

Outlines your rights:

- If you are injured during the study
- To privacy and confidentiality of your medical information
- To withdraw from the study at any time without penalty

6. Contact Information

Provides ways to:

- Learn more about the study
- Ask questions
- Contact the study team
- Learn about participant rights

7. Signature

Signing the form means:

- You understand the information provided
- You agree to participate

Signing does not waive your rights or require you to remain in the study. You may stop participating at any time.

Tips for Reviewing a Consent Form

- ✓ Bring a friend or family member to discussions with the study team.
- ✓ Take the form home and read it carefully in a comfortable setting.
- ✓ Highlight important information and write down questions.
- ✓ Ask a trusted friend, spouse, or healthcare provider to review the form with you.
- ✓ Ask questions whenever something is unclear.
- ✓ Remember that participation is always your choice—even after signing the form.

Important Reminder

The informed consent process continues throughout the study. Your doctor and research team should keep you informed of new information so you can continue making informed decisions about your participation.

Key Takeaway: An informed consent form is designed to help you understand the study, protect your rights, and make the decision that is best for you.

Resources

[The National Cancer Institute](#)

[Are Clinical Trials Safe?](#)

[Why Participate in a Clinical Trial?](#)

[How Do Clinical Trials Work?](#)



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